

KNOWLEDGE OMISSION

Arjun Singh gets back at the prime minister as the HRD Ministry scuttles the initiatives of NKC, some of them Manmohan's pet projects

■ By Shafi Rahman

When the National Knowledge Commission (NKC) was set up with much fanfare three years ago, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had spelt out the tasks and challenges before his pet project: "The task ahead is at many levels—from primary to higher education and research institutions of national excellence. At all levels, there is a need to improve both access and excellence. There are fiscal and administrative challenges to be tackled and there are intellectual and leadership issues to be addressed. We must address them boldly."

Brave words, but the issues are yet to be addressed. Now the toughest challenge for NKC comes from Manmohan's own backyard—from the Human Resource Development (HRD) Ministry. Headed by his *bête noire* Arjun Singh, it has shot down almost all the proposals of NKC for reviving higher education. Sam Pitroda-led NKC has stressed the need to stimulate private investment in education as a means to rev up the higher education sector, bringing cheer to the reformists within the Government. It had also suggested that the Government hand out public resources, especially in the form of land grants, to attract (not-for-profit) private investment.

It seems Arjun is determined to spoil the reforms party. A detailed comment prepared by the ministry in response to the recommendations blames NKC for its feeble grasp of ground realities. The ministry says private sector investment in higher education and public and private partnership can be encouraged only within the ambit of the Supreme Court judgement, which clarifies that private investment in higher education will be based on the principle of non-profit and non-commercial purpose. On a cautionary note, it says appropriate policies should be made for the entry of foreign institutions in India: "The entry of sub-standard and fly-by-night operators has to be prevented."

NKC observes that private investment in university education is almost negligible, whereas in professional education there is de facto privatisation.



"As there is no oppressive regulation with regard to general education, the private sector finds it more rewarding to go into professional education," says the ministry. NKC's call to diversify sources for funding universities has also hit a road-block. It had called for leveraging the land owned by the universities to raise revenue. "Most public universities are sitting on a large reservoir of untapped resources in the form of land. It should be possible to draw up norms and parameters for universities to use the land available to them as a source of finance," NKC had said. "This will create new Nandigrams within campuses. Universities must be encouraged to use their assets optimally. Selling off university land should be done in a manner that the economic motive of earning should not undermine the social objective of higher education," says a ministry official.

While NKC insists that there should be substantial cost recovery from the students by imposing higher fees, the ministry argues this will not work for poor students who want to pursue higher studies. "Revenue generation through student fees beyond 20 per cent of the recurring requirement of universities may seriously affect access to higher education," argues the ministry.

HRD Ministry also offers a word of caution on NKC's recommendation that higher education may be encouraged to forge close links with the industry. "Institutes of higher education should not rely extensively upon the corporate sector for funds, as that might affect the academic autonomy of the institutions,"

STUDY IN NUMBERS

The quality gap widens as NKC and HRD Ministry engage in a turf war

Average quality gaps in the colleges with respect to academic and human resources	Average of all colleges	Benchmark
STR (student teacher ratio)	27	20
STR by permanent teachers	33	30
Number of teachers per college	47	78
Proportion of teachers without M. Phil or Ph.D	57%	0
Number of journals per college	13	22
Students per computer	229	145

Source: Planning Commission